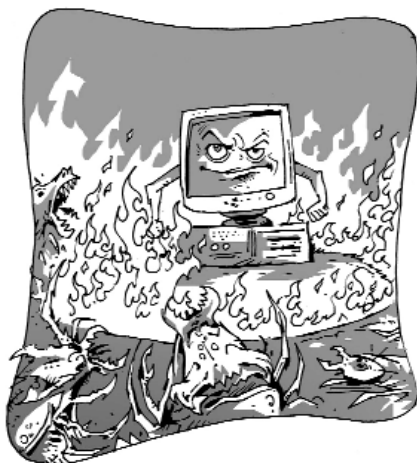


4.2 Firewalls And Other Methods Of Protection



Firewalls were only used as a security method by network administrators to safeguard their servers from unauthorised entry by hackers. The new age of Internet threats and the rise in malicious software means that firewalls are somewhat of a necessity for every computer. Why else would Microsoft include a firewall with its Windows XP SP2 operating system? But before we get into that, let's talk about the basics, starting from what a firewall really is:

In the traditional sense, a firewall is a hardware device or software application that functions in a networked environment to prevent certain communication that's forbidden by security policy. It filters all network packets, and determines whether to allow or block them. It achieves this by screening the requests and determining whether they originate from known and reliable sources. When an unauthorised entry is attempted, say, a hacker trying to access your files, or undetected spyware trying to send out information, the firewall blocks it and also makes your computer invisible to external networks, which is great, as you can't attack what you can't see.